

The 500 Most Important Words for the 11+ Exam

If your child is preparing for the 11+, vocabulary is one of the highest-impact areas to focus on, and one of the most overlooked.

Many children lose marks not because they lack ability, but because they encounter unfamiliar words in comprehension passages, cloze exercises, and verbal reasoning questions. The good news? Vocabulary is entirely learnable with the right approach.

This guide gives you a structured, free list of the most important words for the 11+ exam, organised by difficulty, along with practical tips for helping your child actually remember them.

Why Vocabulary Matters So Much in the 11+

The 11+ tests vocabulary in three main ways:

- Verbal reasoning: synonyms, antonyms, and closest-meaning questions rely almost entirely on word knowledge
- English comprehension: unfamiliar words in a passage slow a child down and cause misunderstanding
- Cloze exercises: filling in missing words requires not just knowing a word, but knowing how it's used

Both major exam boards, GL Assessment and CEM, place significant emphasis on vocabulary. A child with a strong word bank has a meaningful advantage across multiple sections of the exam.

How to Use This Word List

Don't try to learn all the words at once. Here's what works:

- 5–10 words per day, 4–5 days per week
- Start with the foundation words, then move to intermediate and advanced
- For each word: learn the meaning, one synonym, and use it in a sentence
- Review words your child finds difficult more often than easy ones

Short, consistent sessions beat long cramming sessions every time. Even 10 minutes a day adds up to hours of practice over a term.

Foundation Words

50 words

Start here. These words appear frequently in 11+ papers and form the backbone of a strong vocabulary. Many children think they know these, but struggle to define them precisely or identify synonyms.

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Abundant	More than enough, plentiful	Plentiful, ample
Adversity	Difficulty or hardship	Hardship, misfortune
Agile	Able to move quickly and easily	Nimble, lithe
Amiable	Friendly and pleasant	Friendly, affable
Ancient	Very old	Old, archaic
Anxious	Worried or nervous	Worried, uneasy
Audacious	Showing willingness to take bold risks	Bold, daring
Barren	Too poor to produce vegetation	Bare, desolate
Benevolent	Well-meaning and kind	Kind, generous
Bewildered	Confused and unable to understand	Confused, perplexed
Bold	Brave and confident	Brave, daring
Boisterous	Noisy and energetic	Lively, rowdy
Cautious	Being careful about risks	Careful, wary
Cease	To stop	Stop, halt
Cheerful	Noticeably happy	Happy, jolly
Colossal	Extremely large	Huge, enormous
Compassionate	Feeling concern for others	Caring, sympathetic
Concealed	Kept hidden	Hidden, disguised
Considerable	Great in size or extent	Large, significant
Courageous	Not deterred by danger	Brave, bold
Cunning	Clever at achieving goals deceitfully	Crafty, sly
Curious	Eager to know or learn	Inquisitive, nosy
Desolate	Bleak and empty	Bare, barren
Determined	Firm in purpose	Resolute, steadfast
Diligent	Hardworking and careful	Industrious, thorough
Dismal	Gloomy and bleak	Gloomy, dreary
Eager	Keen and enthusiastic	Keen, enthusiastic
Elaborate	Detailed and complicated	Detailed, complex
Elegant	Pleasingly graceful	Graceful, refined
Enormous	Very large	Huge, vast

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Essential	Absolutely necessary	Necessary, vital
Exhausted	Completely tired	Tired, weary
Ferocious	Savagely fierce	Fierce, wild
Fierce	Violent and aggressive	Ferocious, intense
Flexible	Able to bend easily	Adaptable, supple
Fortunate	Lucky	Lucky, blessed
Fragile	Easily broken	Delicate, brittle
Frugal	Economical with money or food	Thrifty, sparing
Furious	Extremely angry	Angry, enraged
Generous	Freely giving	Giving, liberal
Gentle	Mild and kind	Mild, tender
Glorious	Magnificent and splendid	Magnificent, splendid
Gracious	Courteous and kind	Polite, courteous
Grateful	Feeling thankful	Thankful, appreciative
Grave	Serious and solemn	Serious, solemn
Greedy	Having an excessive desire	Selfish, gluttonous
Grim	Stern or forbidding	Stern, harsh
Harsh	Cruel or severe	Severe, brutal
Humble	Not proud or arrogant	Modest, meek
Immense	Extremely large	Vast, enormous

Intermediate Words

49 words

Build on the foundations. Once your child is confident with the foundation list, move to these. They appear regularly in comprehension passages and verbal reasoning sections.

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Absurd	Wildly unreasonable	Ridiculous, ludicrous
Accumulate	Gather together over time	Collect, amass
Adamant	Refusing to change one's mind	Firm, resolute
Adept	Very skilled at something	Skilled, proficient
Adjacent	Next to or adjoining	Neighbouring, nearby
Adverse	Preventing success	Unfavourable, harmful

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Affluent	Having a great deal of wealth	Wealthy, prosperous
Agitate	Make someone troubled	Disturb, unsettle
Aloof	Not friendly or forthcoming	Distant, remote
Ambiguous	Open to more than one interpretation	Unclear, vague
Apprehensive	Worried about the future	Anxious, uneasy
Ardent	Very enthusiastic or passionate	Passionate, fervent
Arduous	Involving a lot of effort	Difficult, strenuous
Arrogant	Having an exaggerated sense of importance	Proud, conceited
Articulate	Able to speak fluently and clearly	Eloquent, fluent
Astute	Able to assess situations quickly	Shrewd, clever
Austere	Severe or strict in manner	Stern, strict
Authentic	Genuine or real	Real, genuine
Avid	Having a keen interest	Keen, enthusiastic
Bewildering	Causing great confusion	Confusing, puzzling
Blatant	Done openly and unashamedly	Obvious, flagrant
Blithe	Showing a casual lack of concern	Carefree, cheerful
Bountiful	Large in quantity	Plentiful, generous
Candid	Truthful and straightforward	Frank, honest
Capable	Having the ability to do something	Able, competent
Captivating	Attracting and holding interest	Charming, fascinating
Cautious	Careful to avoid problems	Careful, wary
Cease	To stop happening	Stop, halt
Celestial	Positioned in or relating to the sky	Heavenly, divine
Chaotic	In a state of complete confusion	Disorderly, frenzied
Circumspect	Wary and unwilling to take risks	Careful, cautious
Clamour	A loud, confused noise	Din, uproar
Clandestine	Kept secret or hidden	Secret, covert
Coerce	Persuade someone by force	Force, compel
Coherent	Logical and consistent	Logical, clear
Complacent	Smugly satisfied with oneself	Self-satisfied, smug

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Concede	Admit something is true	Admit, acknowledge
Condemn	Express complete disapproval	Criticise, denounce
Conspicuous	Clearly visible	Obvious, noticeable
Contemplate	Think about something carefully	Consider, ponder
Contemptuous	Showing that something is worthless	Scornful, disdainful
Controversial	Causing disagreement	Debatable, contentious
Convey	Transport or communicate	Carry, communicate
Cordial	Warm and friendly	Friendly, warm
Credulous	Too ready to believe things	Gullible, naive
Crestfallen	Sad and disappointed	Dejected, downcast
Cryptic	Having a hidden meaning	Mysterious, puzzling
Cunning	Skilled at achieving goals deviously	Crafty, sly
Curious	Eager to know	Inquisitive, interested

Advanced Words

221 words

For exam readiness. These words appear in the most challenging 11+ papers and are often the difference between a good and an outstanding score.

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Abate	Become less intense	Lessen, diminish
Abdicate	Fail to fulfil responsibility	Renounce, relinquish
Aberrant	Departing from normal	Abnormal, deviant
Abhor	Regard with disgust	Detest, loathe
Abjure	Solemnly renounce	Renounce, forswear
Abnegate	Renounce a belief	Reject, abandon
Abrogate	Repeal a law	Abolish, revoke
Abstemious	Not self-indulgent	Moderate, restrained
Abstruse	Difficult to understand	Complex, obscure
Acerbic	Sharp and forthright	Sharp, cutting
Acrimony	Bitterness or ill feeling	Bitterness, hostility
Acumen	The ability to make good judgements	Shrewdness, insight
Admonish	Warn or reprimand firmly	Reprimand, rebuke

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Adroit	Clever or skilful	Skilful, deft
Affable	Friendly and easy to talk to	Friendly, amiable
Alacrity	Brisk and cheerful readiness	Eagerness, willingness
Alleviate	Make suffering less severe	Ease, relieve
Altruistic	Showing unselfish concern for others	Selfless, charitable
Ambivalent	Having mixed feelings	Uncertain, undecided
Ameliorate	Make something bad better	Improve, better
Amiable	Having a pleasant manner	Friendly, agreeable
Amicable	Done in a friendly spirit	Friendly, cordial
Anachronism	Something out of its time	Archaism, relic
Anarchy	Disorder from lack of authority	Chaos, disorder
Antagonise	Cause hostility in someone	Provoke, irritate
Apathy	Lack of interest or concern	Indifference, lethargy
Appease	Pacify by making concessions	Pacify, placate
Arcane	Known only by a few	Mysterious, obscure
Ardour	Great enthusiasm or passion	Passion, enthusiasm
Assiduous	Showing great care and effort	Diligent, industrious
Astute	Quickly assessing situations	Shrewd, perceptive
Atone	Make amends	Repent, compensate
Audacious	Showing daring boldness	Bold, daring
Auspicious	Suggesting a good future	Promising, favourable
Avarice	Extreme greed for wealth	Greed, covetousness
Beguile	Charm or trick someone	Charm, deceive
Belligerent	Hostile and aggressive	Aggressive, hostile
Bemoan	Express discontent about	Lament, complain
Benign	Gentle and kindly	Kind, harmless
Brazen	Bold and without shame	Shameless, impudent
Brevity	Concise and exact use of words	Conciseness, shortness
Brisk	Active and energetic	Lively, energetic
Buoyant	Cheerful and optimistic	Cheerful, light-hearted

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Cajole	Persuade by flattery	Coax, persuade
Callous	Showing no concern for others	Uncaring, heartless
Capitulate	Cease to resist	Surrender, yield
Capricious	Given to sudden changes	Unpredictable, fickle
Censure	Express severe disapproval	Condemn, criticise
Chastise	Rebuke or punish	Scold, reprimand
Churlish	Rude in an unfriendly way	Rude, surly
Clemency	Mercy shown to an offender	Mercy, leniency
Colossal	Extremely large	Enormous, gigantic
Compunction	Anxiety from guilt	Remorse, guilt
Condescending	Showing a low opinion of others	Patronising, superior
Confound	Cause surprise or confusion	Baffle, perplex
Consternation	A feeling of great worry	Dismay, alarm
Contemplate	Think about carefully	Ponder, consider
Contrite	Feeling regret for wrongdoing	Remorseful, sorry
Convolved	Extremely complex	Complex, intricate
Copious	Abundant in supply	Plentiful, ample
Covert	Not openly done	Secret, hidden
Credible	Able to be believed	Believable, plausible
Culpable	Responsible for a fault	Guilty, blameworthy
Cursory	Hasty and not detailed	Brief, superficial
Cynical	Distrustful of human goodness	Sceptical, distrustful
Dauntless	Fearless	Fearless, intrepid
Debilitate	Make someone very weak	Weaken, enfeeble
Deceitful	Guilty of deceiving	Dishonest, misleading
Deference	Humble submission to another	Respect, submission
Deliberate	Done with full awareness	Intentional, planned
Denounce	Publicly declare wrong	Condemn, censure
Deplete	Use up the supply of	Exhaust, drain
Derision	Contemptuous ridicule	Mockery, scorn

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Despondent	In low spirits from loss	Downcast, dejected
Devious	Showing a willingness to deceive	Cunning, sly
Diligent	Having steady effort	Hardworking, assiduous
Discreet	Careful not to cause offence	Tactful, careful
Disdain	The feeling of contempt	Scorn, contempt
Disparage	Regard as unworthy	Belittle, deprecate
Dubious	Hesitating or doubting	Doubtful, uncertain
Duplicitous	Deceitful	Deceitful, dishonest
Eccentricity	Unusual behaviour	Oddness, quirk
Egregious	Outstandingly bad	Shocking, outrageous
Eloquent	Fluent and persuasive in speaking	Articulate, fluent
Eminent	Famous and respected	Distinguished, notable
Empathy	Ability to understand another's feelings	Compassion, understanding
Endeavour	Try hard to do something	Try, attempt
Enigmatic	Difficult to interpret	Mysterious, puzzling
Enormous	Very large	Vast, immense
Equivocal	Open to more than one interpretation	Ambiguous, unclear
Erroneous	Wrong; incorrect	Mistaken, incorrect
Evasive	Tending to avoid commitment	Elusive, shifty
Exasperate	Irritate greatly	Frustrate, infuriate
Exemplary	Serving as a desirable model	Outstanding, admirable
Exhaustive	Including all elements	Complete, thorough
Exhilarating	Making one feel very happy	Thrilling, exciting
Explicit	Stated clearly	Clear, direct
Exuberant	Filled with lively energy	Enthusiastic, vivacious
Facetious	Treating something serious as amusing	Flippant, frivolous
Fallacious	Based on a mistaken belief	False, misleading
Fastidious	Very attentive to accuracy	Meticulous, particular
Fathom	Understand after much thought	Understand, comprehend
Fervent	Having strong feelings	Passionate, ardent

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Fervour	Intense passionate feeling	Passion, enthusiasm
Flagrant	Conspicuously wrong	Blatant, obvious
Flippant	Not showing respect	Disrespectful, glib
Flourish	Grow or develop in a healthy way	Thrive, prosper
Forlorn	Pitifully sad	Sad, miserable
Formidable	Inspiring fear through size	Daunting, impressive
Fortitude	Courage in the face of pain	Courage, resilience
Frugal	Being economical	Thrifty, careful
Futile	Producing no results	Useless, pointless
Garrulous	Excessively talkative	Talkative, chatty
Gratuitous	Uncalled for	Unnecessary, unwarranted
Gregarious	Fond of company	Sociable, outgoing
Guile	Sly or cunning intelligence	Cunning, deceit
Gullible	Easily persuaded to believe things	Naive, credulous
Harrowing	Acutely distressing	Distressing, traumatic
Haughty	Arrogantly superior	Arrogant, proud
Hazardous	Risky or dangerous	Dangerous, perilous
Heed	Pay attention to	Notice, consider
Heretic	A person who holds unorthodox opinions	Dissenter, rebel
Hilarity	Extreme amusement	Amusement, laughter
Hostile	Unfriendly	Aggressive, antagonistic
Humility	A modest view of one's importance	Modesty, meekness
Hypocritical	Behaving in a false way	Two-faced, insincere
Idiosyncratic	Peculiar to an individual	Quirky, eccentric
Ignorant	Lacking knowledge	Unaware, uninformed
Immutable	Unchanging over time	Fixed, permanent
Impartial	Treating all rivals equally	Fair, unbiased
Impetuous	Acting without thought	Rash, hasty
Implacable	Unable to be appeased	Relentless, merciless
Implicit	Suggested without being stated	Implied, indirect

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Impudent	Not showing due respect	Rude, insolent
Incisive	Intelligently analytical	Sharp, acute
Incredulous	Unwilling or unable to believe	Disbelieving, sceptical
Indifferent	Having no interest	Unconcerned, apathetic
Indignant	Feeling righteous anger	Angry, offended
Indolent	Wanting to avoid activity	Lazy, idle
Inept	Having no skill	Incompetent, clumsy
Inexorable	Impossible to stop	Relentless, unstoppable
Infamous	Well known for bad qualities	Notorious, disgraceful
Ingenious	Clever and inventive	Clever, inventive
Innate	Inborn	Natural, inborn
Inquisitive	Curious to learn	Curious, enquiring
Insidious	Proceeding in a gradual harmful way	Sneaky, subtle
Insolent	Showing a rude lack of respect	Rude, impertinent
Integrity	The quality of being honest	Honesty, honour
Intrepid	Fearless	Fearless, brave
Irate	Feeling very angry	Angry, furious
Judicious	Having good judgement	Wise, sensible
Languid	Displaying little energy	Weak, listless
Lavish	Sumptuously rich	Extravagant, generous
Lax	Not sufficiently strict	Slack, careless
Lethargic	Affected by sluggishness	Sluggish, slow
Loquacious	Tending to talk a great deal	Talkative, garrulous
Ludicrous	So foolish as to be funny	Ridiculous, absurd
Magnanimous	Generous in forgiving	Generous, forgiving
Malevolent	Having a wish to harm others	Malicious, spiteful
Meticulous	Taking great care	Careful, precise
Mitigate	Make less severe	Lessen, reduce
Morose	Sullen and ill-tempered	Sulky, gloomy
Mundane	Lacking interest	Ordinary, dull

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Nonchalant	Feeling no worry	Calm, casual
Notorious	Famous for something bad	Infamous, disreputable
Oblivious	Not aware of	Unaware, ignorant
Obstinate	Stubbornly refusing to change	Stubborn, pigheaded
Obtuse	Slow to understand	Slow, dull
Ominous	Giving a feeling of fear	Threatening, sinister
Ostracise	Exclude from a group	Exclude, shun
Pacify	Bring peace to	Calm, appease
Pensive	Engaged in deep thought	Thoughtful, reflective
Perilous	Full of danger	Dangerous, hazardous
Persevere	Continue despite difficulty	Persist, continue
Petulant	Childishly sulky	Sulky, irritable
Placid	Not easily upset	Calm, peaceful
Pompous	Affectedly grand	Self-important, arrogant
Pragmatic	Dealing with things practically	Practical, realistic
Precarious	Not securely held	Unstable, risky
Presumptuous	Too confident	Arrogant, bold
Procrastinate	Delay doing something	Delay, postpone
Profound	Very great or intense	Deep, intense
Prolific	Producing much	Productive, fertile
Prudent	Acting with care and thought	Sensible, wise
Querulous	Complaining in a petulant way	Complaining, whining
Rancour	Bitterness from feeling wronged	Bitterness, resentment
Rash	Acting without careful thought	Impulsive, reckless
Raucous	Making a harsh, loud noise	Noisy, rowdy
Reticent	Not revealing thoughts	Reserved, quiet
Rigorous	Extremely thorough	Thorough, strict
Ruse	A trick intended to deceive	Trick, ploy
Sagacious	Having good judgement	Wise, shrewd
Sarcastic	Mocking or meaning the opposite	Mocking, cutting

WORD	MEANING	COMMON SYNONYM
Sceptical	Not easily convinced	Doubtful, cynical
Serene	Calm and peaceful	Calm, tranquil
Shrewd	Having practical intelligence	Astute, clever
Sinister	Giving a sense of evil	Threatening, ominous
Solemn	Formal and dignified	Serious, grave
Sombre	Dark or dull in tone	Gloomy, dark
Steadfast	Resolutely firm	Firm, resolute
Stoic	Enduring pain without complaint	Patient, uncomplaining
Subtle	Hard to detect	Understated, delicate
Sullen	Bad-tempered and sulky	Moody, gloomy
Superfluous	Unnecessary	Unnecessary, excess
Suppress	Forcibly put an end to	Subdue, stifle
Surreptitious	Kept secret	Secret, covert
Tempestuous	Very stormy	Stormy, turbulent
Tenacious	Holding firm to something	Persistent, determined
Tentative	Not certain or fixed	Hesitant, uncertain
Timid	Showing a lack of courage	Shy, fearful
Tranquil	Free from disturbance	Calm, peaceful
Treacherous	Guilty of betrayal	Disloyal, traitorous
Turbulent	Moving unsteadily	Unstable, stormy
Unscrupulous	Without moral principles	Dishonest, unprincipled
Vacuous	Having a lack of thought	Empty, vacant
Venerable	Accorded great respect	Respected, esteemed
Vigilant	Keeping careful watch	Alert, watchful
Vivacious	Attractively lively	Lively, spirited
Volatile	Liable to change rapidly	Unpredictable, unstable
Wary	Cautious about dangers	Cautious, careful
Zealous	Having great energy for a cause	Passionate, fervent

Tips for Learning These Words

Make It a Daily Habit

Short daily sessions are far more effective than weekly cramming. Even 10 minutes a day over three months adds up to over 15 hours of practice.

Test in Both Directions

Don't just learn word-to-meaning. Practise the other direction too: being given a definition and finding the word. This is exactly what verbal reasoning questions require.

Learn Synonyms Together

The 11+ frequently asks children to identify the word closest in meaning to another. Learning synonyms alongside each word is one of the most targeted ways to prepare.

Use the Words in Real Sentences

Encourage your child to use a new word in conversation or writing each day. Using a word actively helps it move from short-term to long-term memory.

Focus on the Difficult Ones

If your child gets a word right consistently, move on. Spend more time on words they find difficult. This is how your child makes the fastest progress.

Practise These Words With the 11+ Words App

If you want your child to learn these words in a structured, engaging way, without you having to quiz them yourself, the 11+ Words app is completely free and built specifically for this.

The app includes:

- Structured word lists organised by difficulty
- Flashcard review sessions
- Multiple quiz types that mirror 11+ exam formats
- Adaptive practice so harder words come up more often
- Progress tracking so you can see what's been learned

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Word selection is based on common 11+ exam requirements across both GL Assessment and CEM exam boards.